Death of Bliss

By Jules Tasca

*[Lights come up on **KAHLID:** Akka, a young Palestinian man. **KAHLID:** paces. He looks at his watch.]*

KAHLID: [To himself] Why isn't she home? Sana Sana... Sana...where are you? [He looks at his watch. He paces some more.] Where could she have gone? [Khalid lifts a coat from a chair. There is a vest under the coat. The vest is packed with explosives and held together with duct tape. He puts on the vest and looks in the mirror. He is proud of what he sees.] Praise the name of Khalid Akka! Yes...yes...God is great. [He removes the vest-bomb and replaces it on the chair. He steps back and regards it. He hears footsteps. Quickly, he covers the vest-bomb with his coat. His wife, Sana, a young Palestinian woman, enters. She wears a head scarf and carries a small knapsack.] Sana, where have you been?!

INTRODUCTION

What brings a young Palestinian man to detonate himself amidst a crowd of unsuspecting citizens? Is it a religious upbringing with promises of paradise in reward for acts of martyrdom? Is it the parental and family support he receives for his convictions? Is it brainwashing, or rather encouragement from a Palestinian society with no other means of fighting back against oppression and humiliation? Regardless of the motivation for this type of self-sacrificing terrorism, the results are the same: loss of life, increase in fear and The Death of Bliss by Jules Tasca..

SANA: What's the matter?

KAHLID: What's the matter? I am waiting for you.

SANA: I had an errand to run.

KAHLID: Errand?

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SANA: Yes, an errand. So? Usually, you spend your lunch hour with the men drinking tea and smoking and going on and on about the Jews.

KAHLID: Going on and on about the Jews...

SANA: Well, you do.

KAHLID: Is that how you see me, your husband? As some kind of kiosk attendant who fills his free time with empty talk, going on and on about the Jews?

SANA: I didn't say...

KAHLID: You said on and on...on and on about the Jews...as though your husband is nothing but a tea shop talker.

SANA: It's not just you. Khalid, I didn't mean just you.

KAHLID: You meant what then?

SANA: It's all of us. Who talks of anything but them? That's our lives now. The Jews and what they do to us.

KAHLID: The Jews are our oppressors. The Jews are our occupiers. The Jews stole our land. The Jews give us pain. People...people talk about what pains them, Sana.

SANA: I know.

KAHLID: So until the Jews are gone, there will be no other topic but the Jews! Understood? [A beat of silence.]

SANA: Khalid, I'm tired. I don't feel so good. I don't want to talk about the Jews right now.

KAHLID: Sana, you have to talk about them now.

SANA: Right now? Why?

KAHLID: Because... because Jews are an infection in the land of Palestine. You fight an infection before it kills everyone.

SANA: I've heard it all before. Why at this moment.. .Will you stop pacing back and forth.

KAHLID: Sana...

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SANA: What?

KAHLID: My brother...he...he...

SANA: Your brother what?

KAHLID: He came to me at the kiosk today. Then we came here.

SANA: Your brother, Ibrahim, he was here today?

KAHLID: Yes and he...he...

SANA: Khalid, what?

KAHLID: Sana, I am being honored.

SANA: You are being...

KAHLID: Honored. Yes, I am.

SANA: What're you talking about? [A beat of silence. Khalid looks at her] Khalid, what honor?. .Husband?

KAHLID: He, Ibrahim, he dropped off the vest.

SANA: The vest... you mean.. . Khalid, you mean one of those vests that. ..

KAHLID: Yes.

SANA: A bomb?

KAHLID: Yes.

SANA: No... [Khalid crosses and removes the coat from the chair, revealing the vest-bomb. Sana slowly crosses to it.]

KAHLID: Don't touch it.

SANA: You...you know about these...these vests.

KAHLID: They trained me and Ibrahim both. Showed us how to.. .how to detonate it.

SANA: When did you...

KAHLID: We took training.

SANA: Secretly.

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KAHLID: Secretly. Yes. Sure. From the authority. Yes, I did. See there are two metal pieces here in the pocket covered with tape. Once you remove the tape from each strip of metal, you.. .you touch the strips together and...

SANA: And you are dead.. .you don't need much training to be dead.

KAHLID: It is an honor to be selected.

SANA: I didn't...

KAHLID: You didn't what, Sana?

SANA: Know. I didn't know that...

KAHLID: That I had placed the name of Khalid Akka on the list of those willing. No, you didn't know. I couldn't tell.

SANA: Couldn't tell me? Couldn't tell your own wife that you took training.

KAHLID: I told no one. The handlers told us to tell no one. There are those among us who for Israeli money would turn us in.

SANA: And Ibrahim, his name is on the list too?

KAHLID: Sure.

SANA: Why then you?

KAHLID: The authority chooses...

SANA: Why you and not Ibrahim?

KAHLID: I think...I think because... because I work the kiosk at the Grand Market, no one would suspect me. It'll be crowded tonight, because of the start of the Jewish holiday and I...

SANA: And you're going back to work with this vest under your coat to... to...

KAHLID: My loving wife...I knew this would be hard for us.

SANA: But your loving wife has nothing to say about it.

KAHLID: Why would a wife or mother or any woman have a right to keep me from...from...from meting out punishment to the infidels?

SANA: No. How could any woman keep you from such an honor.

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KAHLID: It is an honor, a high honor.

SANA: Khalid, we stand in our apartment and we talk of your death as if you were going out for cigarettes.

KAHLID: No. I...I am on edge. My palms are wet. My nerves are all out of their pockets. But.. .you.. .you are supposed to hold your head up high, my loving wife. There is... underneath the tension. .. there is a pride...

SANA: Pride.

KAHLID: Don't you feel it?

SANA: I'm to be proud also?

KAHLID: You're not? You're not proud?

SANA: I am just...just shocked...

KAHLID: I know.

SANA: You took training...you're serious...

KAHLID: I think we must battle the occupation. That fight is the marrow in these bones.

SANA: I just feel numb.. .numbness.. .

KAHLID: My wife, you must understand. My brother told me-no promised me, vowed to me-that you would be taken care of. You will stay in the apartment. You will receive money regularly. You will be celebrated as the wife...

SANA: Who lost her husband.

KAHLID: As the wife of a martyr. Thousands will march through the streets for my funeral. Our men will carry my coffin draped with the flag. The shots they fire in salute of me shall be my voice from the grave...and you... Sana...will march with me and wear my honor like a queen's crown.

SANA: Khalid.. . Khalid.. .how full the pride that overflows those eyes, eyes more precious to me than all the martyrs in heaven.

KAHLID: Sana...

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SANA: You can strike me if you will, but no, I will not lie to you. I do not respect this anymore.

KAHLID: Wife...

SANA: For the Jews we are destroying ourselves. For the Jews we rupture our families. In my bones there is only sorrow.

KAHLID: You dishonor your own brother by saying this. Your brother, Hanni, honored your family by...

SANA: Driving a car of explosives into a restaurant. Don't let me remember. My Hanni...

KAHLID: He killed eight Jews and injured over twenty more.

SANA: And killed three Palestinians on the wait staff. Our hate bites its own tail.

KAHLID: It's a war of sacrifice.

SANA: I know. I grew up without a brother.

KAHLID: He was a warrior, the same as Ibrahim and I are. Oh, Sana, I know that life is bliss, but it is the bliss of a moment. After such a sacrifice is the bliss of forever. The bliss of God. Your brother, Hanni, is with Allah. He is a hero. I always wanted to live up to your brother's name.

SANA: When Hanni died it was the death of bliss for me. And now...now...husband, how can a wife be happy?

KAHLID: It is not a time to be happy. It is a time to be strong. I..I will miss you too. So much. But look, I go to God and His paradise.

SANA: And so you do. You go to God and I, your wife, go to the funeral.

KAHLID: Sana.. . Sana, I...I never thought you'd have this attitude.

SANA: How could you? How could I? We don't know the burn until the lightning hits.

KAHLID: We're at war. These are the acts of war. We're all soldiers, all of us, all of our people. I'm just waiting for you to say something that makes me know you

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understand...Wife? Sana? I...I thought...I mean to say, I saw this time as us holding each other as tight as love can grip two people and I thought...

SANA: I don't feel that way. I'm sorry.

KAHLID: This stance you've taken...

SANA: What stance?

KAHLID: This wall you're putting up. One could interpret this as being against the uprising.

SANA: We live the uprising. We breathe the uprising. Today I'm breathing uprising instead of air. It's choking me that you. . . that you...

KAHLID: You would talk me out of it. ..

SANA: I love you. In the eye of the uprising I love you.

KAHLID: I know you do. And 1...1 am...I am afraid, Sana. I am. But my...my duty to my country...

SANA: What about your duty to the living. Your...your family...your...

KAHLID: My mother knows. I stopped there already. Oh, yes, she was upset, but Ibrahim and I soothed her with the pride that will come after...

SANA: Pride. What are we to do with this pride. How can we love pride more than life? [Khalid crosses to the chair holding the vest.]

KAHLID: I have no more time for women's hysterics. I am leaving. Say something to me, Sana. Say something to me that will last me forever.. . Sana?

SANA: I am going to have a child. [A beat of silence. He crosses from the chair to Sana]

KAHLID: Are you saying this because...

SANA: I am going to have a child.

KAHLID: Sweet heaven...oh, Sana...you are... [He embraces her]

SANA: Yes... I was at the clinic this morning.

KAHLID: You were at...

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SANA: Yes, the clinic. That's why I was late.

KAHLID: And the doctor confirms that...

SANA: Yes. Two months.

KAHLID: Pregnant...

SANA: I am two months...

KAHLID: Two months along. Oh, my Sana...oh, my dear wife...

SANA: I came home today to tell you of this honor. [Sana moves away from him.] But now there is...there is an ache in my stomach. Today, when the doctor told me, in my womb I felt a beautiful sensation, a tingle of joy. Now.. .now, there is discomfort there...a gnawing, as if what's inside me recoils with a little startle of grief...

KAHLID: Now, after almost two years.. .now. ..now you become...

SANA: If I...If I had known...Oh God if only I had known...

KAHLID: There was no way to know that I would be selected.

SANA: No. No. I know that. But surely now you...you can...

KAHLID: I can what?

SANA: You can...you can call Ibrahim. You can call your brother and you.. .

KAHLID: I can do what? Call it off? Back out?

SANA: You must...

KAHLID: How? How can I call it off? The leadership. They're expecting the Grand Market of Jerusalem to be a windstorm of shrapnel. They expect Jewish flesh and oppressors' mouths to foam blood. They expect the air as thick as cream with their cries and moans...

SANA: And what about your own flesh, husband?

KAHLID: It doesn't matter. I swore during training by Almighty God who holds the heavens above our heads, Sana, that the Jews will never live secure until they leave the land of Mohammed.

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SANA: And what about this child who sits here in the limbo of life and waits for the world to pull him out? [A beat of silence. Khalid stares at her. Then he crosses away.]

KAHLID: I...I...I never...I never counted on such a thing. You-my wife. I made Ibrahim promise to Allah that you would be taken care of. But I never counted on.. .on...

SANA: You know what it would be like, Khalid, for a child to call you father? Do you know how it will feel to have him or her run to the door when you come home? To have a bouquet of kisses flood your face? And there would be more pride in that than having your picture in your mother's front window dressed in carnations and draped with a flag dripping with honor.

KAHLID: Oh, my Sana, how much I love you. Your words are still electric to me. Sana... Sana, love of my life, you are trying to change the world with your love of me.

SANA: I won't say I'm sorry if...if what I say changes your mind.

KAHLID: But it's not so simple. Women. Wake up. Everything's so easy for women.

SANA: Only men say that.

KAHLID: Sana, it's not possible for me to...

SANA: Why not? Call Ibrahim. Tell him what happened.

KAHLID: Sweet woman...

SANA: Please.. .If you love me... please... [Sana crosses to the table and picks up a cell phone. She crosses back to Khalid with it. She hands it to him.] Please.. . [Khalid sits.]

KAHLID: I...I will be called a coward. Sana, the leadership doesn't care about your baby.

SANA: Our baby.

KAHLID: That baby.. .my son... will be told of this if I back out. You know how a reputation gotten is a brand forever here. Khalid Akka, they'll say, he was chosen to sacrifice for his people, for Palestine, for our children's future and he.. .he...

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SANA: We can go away.

KAHLID: [Rising.] They'd still all know. My family, my friends. My brother and mother disgraced. Wherever we went, we'd trail my wobbly reputation behind me.

SANA: I want my husband with me. If that makes me a traitor so be it.

KAHLID: Don't say that. Ever...you are not a traitor. You are the wife of Khalid Akka. My son will never be disgraced by his father. I...I...I leave to you and him a legacy of honor... [Khalid embraces her. Then he crosses to the chair and puts on the vest, next his coat to mask the vest. Sana stares away. Khalid crosses back to her.] Sana...I love you... Sana...But I must. It is impossible to do otherwise...God is great. He has seen fit to leave me alive in you... [Khalid kneels and kisses Sana's stomach.] God is great, Sana... Sana . . .

SANA: [Softly.] God.. .is.. .great... [Khalid rises and kisses her.]

KAHLID: Pray for me... [Khalid exits.]

SANA: [As lights fade.] I pray...I pray...I pray that-boy or girl-I pray that I lose it...I pray that I never have it...!...I pray...I pray...I pray...

SOURCE INFORMATION

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